

THE NORSE WORDS

The vocabulary the best chapters of this book are built on. Baring-Gould read Old Norse and assumed a reader who could follow him; a modern reader cannot, and the strongest argument in the book is made in words it never explains.

Word	What it means
berserkr	Old Norse. A warrior who fought in a frenzy said to be beyond his own control. The word is usually read as “bear-shirt”, from the skin he was said to wear; “bare-shirt”, a man who fought without mail, is an old and still defensible alternative. Baring-Gould takes the first as settled. It is not.
úlfeðinn	Old Norse, “wolf-coat”. The wolf-skinned counterpart of the berserk, and the closer of the two to the werewolf of the folk tradition.
hamr	Old Norse. A skin, a covering, a shape. The word carries all three senses at once, which is exactly why the Norse werewolf is hard to pin down: to change your hamr may mean to put on a hide or to change what you are.
hamrammr	Old Norse, shape-strong. A man able to change his hamr. The sagas use it of people who are formidable rather than of people who are monstrous.
eigi einhamr	Old Norse, “not of one skin”. Said of a man who is more than he appears.
vargr	Old Norse. Both a wolf and an outlaw — a man placed outside the law, whom anyone might kill. The double sense is the hinge of Baring-Gould’s best argument.
versipellis	Latin, “turn-skin”. The word Petronius uses, and the nearest classical term for a werewolf.
Aigla	Baring-Gould’s name for Egils saga Skallagrímssonar, the source of Kveldúlf, the Evening Wolf.
Kveldúlf	“Evening Wolf”. The grandfather of Egil in the saga, a man said to grow savage as the light failed. Baring-Gould treats him as the best single piece of evidence that the Norse werewolf was a description of a temperament.
Völsunga saga	The thirteenth-century prose saga in which Sigmund and Sinfjötli put on wolf-skins and cannot take them off for nine days.

The argument in one line. A vargr is a wolf and an outlaw, and Norse law used the word for a man put outside the peace, whom anyone might kill. If your language already contains a category for a person who has become a wolf in the eyes of the community, you do not need mythology to explain what happens when a man behaves like one.

From The Book of Were-Wolves by Sabine Baring-Gould, Valice Classics 15. Free at valicepress.com/companion-book-of-were-wolves